

DISABILITY INCLUSION · ACCESSIBILITY · POLICY & RESEARCH

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

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I work in disability-inclusive development, with field grounding across India and policy assignments at international level. Currently Advisor - Inclusion, Systems & Partnerships at *Snehadhara Foundation*, Bengaluru. Most recently completed a tenure as Assistant Professor then Consultant with the Office of Disability Inclusion at Azim Premji University (Dec 2022 - Mar 2026). Two assignments with the WHO Disability Unit in Geneva contributed to the *Global Report on Health Equity for Persons with Disabilities* (2022); World Bank work on the TN RIGHTS project supported the Government of Tamil Nadu; and an earlier posting in Bihar produced the State Disability Inclusion Guideline, in implementation since 2020.

A FEW HIGHLIGHTS

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PROJECT

Disability Rights Repository - *a small portal I maintain, to give visibility to community-based grassroots practitioners and support documentation by OPD leaders.*

INITIATIVE

EquitableDocs · equitabledocs.org - *a non-commercial pipeline for accessible academic documents for the Global South. Check, repair, train. Free for individuals and government; cost-only for institutions.*

EDUCATION

Mid-career MA, Development Studies, Graduate Institute Geneva (full scholarship) - *MA & MPhil Political Science, JNU New Delhi.*

EARLIER WORK

Bihar State Disability Inclusion Guideline - *developed during my time as State Disability Consultant for JEEViKA; in implementation since August 2020.*

CERTIFICATION

IAAP Certified Professional in Accessibility Core Competencies (CPACC) - *and Disability Rights & Accessibility certification, US Institute of Diplomacy & Human Rights, Washington, DC.*

CURRENTLY

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2024 - PRESENT	Advisor - Inclusion, Systems & Partnerships / <i>Snehadhara Foundation, Bengaluru</i> Strengthening inclusion approaches within partner organisations; accessibility advisory across programmes, spaces and documentation; supporting proposal development, strategic planning and government-linked institutional partnerships.
FROM JAN 2026	Drafting committee member / <i>State Disability Policy, Govt. of Tamil Nadu - Department for the Welfare of Differently Abled</i> Two-member committee, onboarded 7 January 2026.
ACTIVE	Member, Disability Informatics Sub-Committee MHD 17:3 / <i>Bureau of Indian Standards - Medical Equipment & Hospital Planning Division Council, Govt. of India</i>
ACTIVE	Technical Committee member / <i>Purple Building Certification Scheme - accessibility rating for public buildings (launched April 2025)</i>

EXPERIENCE

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2024 - PRESENT	Advisor - Inclusion, Systems & Partnerships / Snehadhara Foundation, Bengaluru Strengthening inclusion within partner organisations; accessibility advisory across programmes, spaces and documentation; proposal development, strategic planning and institutional partnerships.
DEC 2022 - MAR 2026	Assistant Professor, then Consultant / Office of Disability Inclusion, Azim Premji University Assistant Professor (Dec 2022 - Jul 2025); Consultant (Jul 2025 - Mar 2026). - Initiated and developed the reasonable-accommodation process, and disability-inclusion and accessibility interventions across the University. - Designed and delivered training and faculty-development sessions; liaised with faculty, departments and external experts.
AUG 2023 - DEC 2023	Consultant (2nd assignment) / WHO HQ Disability Unit, Geneva Review of WHO documents for disability inclusion components; supported the team with mapping of DPOs across countries, especially LMICs.
OCT 2021 - SEP 2022	Consultant / WHO HQ Disability Unit, Geneva Scoping review on health emergencies and disability inclusion, in support of the WHO <i>Global Report on Health Equity for Persons with Disabilities</i> (2022); coordinated ISL interpreters during stakeholder consultations.
2021 - 2022	Consultant / World Bank - TN RIGHTS, Govt. of Tamil Nadu Initiated and facilitated a CBR core group toward a draft CBR policy submitted to the Government partner; supported the TN team on the CBR implementation plan and accessibility inputs to the project OMIP.
MAY - JUN 2022	UN OHCHR Consultant (short-term research) / Mandate of the UN Special Rapporteur on the elimination of discrimination against persons affected by leprosy Policy compilation and analysis on inclusion of leprosy-affected persons in global disability policy; submitted a research report on leprosy and disability rights in the Global South.
OCT - DEC 2020	Research Intern / International Disability Alliance, Geneva · short-term research, Light for the World
2018-19, 2020-21	State Disability Consultant / JEEViKA - State Rural Livelihoods Mission, Govt. of Bihar Mainstreamed disability inclusion across the state poverty-alleviation programme. Developed the Disability Inclusion Guideline, in implementation since August 2020.
2018	Disability Resource Person / Odisha Livelihoods Mission - Panchayati Raj & Drinking Water Dept., Govt. of Odisha Training modules, staff sensitisation, and a three-day district/block orientation workshop.
2011 - 2017	EARLIER ROLES
2016-17	State Disability Consultant, Sightsavers India (Bihar) - Sightsavers-BRLPS partnership; SHG micro-plans; financial-inclusion workshops; district/block staff training.
2016	National Volunteer, VSO Action Research Project (Jharkhand) - 'Enhancing Employability of Youth with Disabilities through Inclusive ITI Curriculum', published in <i>Empowering Children with Disabilities</i>.
2014-15	Researcher / Documentation, Shanta Memorial Rehabilitation Centre - USAID WWDIN Project.
2013-16	Research Fellow, SDRS - Society for Disability and Rehabilitation Studies, New Delhi.
2011-13	SYLFF Fellow, Ryoichi Sasakawa Young Leaders Fund - JNU; mentor to Viklang Adhikar Manch (Bihar) and Divyang Adhikar Manch (Jharkhand).

EDUCATION

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- 2019 - 2021 **Mid-career MA, Development Studies / Graduate Institute Geneva (IHEID) - full scholarship**
Thesis: a case study on NRLM and disability inclusion.
- 2003 - 2007 **MA & MPhil, Political Science / Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi**
Dissertation: *Approaches to Disability: Norms, Discourse and Policy*.
- 2008 - 2009 **PG Diploma, Special Education (Neurological & Multiple Disabilities) / School of Rehabilitation Sciences, University of Delhi**

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS

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1. 'Enabling Policies', *Yojana*, Publications Division, Govt. of India, Dec 2020.
2. Friedner, Ghosh & Palaniappan, '"Cross-Disability" in India? On the Limits of Disability as a Category and the Work of Negotiating Impairments', *SAMAJ - South Asia Multidisciplinary Academic Journal*.
3. Palaniappan & Rodrigues, 'Disability within the Rawlsian Framework of Justice', in A. Ghai (ed.), *Disability in South Asia: Knowledge and Experience*, Sage, 2018.
4. Palaniappan & Guru, 'Skill Training for Adolescents with Disabilities: A Situational Analysis of Government ITIs in Jharkhand', in Sonpal & Vaishnav (eds.), *Empowering Children with Disabilities*.
5. 'Inner Marginalities and Sub-Group Politicization within the Disability Movement', *Café Dissensus*, 15 Aug 2016.
6. 'ICT4D and Accessibility', Conf. Proc., Natl. Symposium on Disability, Assistive Technology and Farming, ICAR-CIAE Bhopal, Mar 2016.
7. Book Review, *International Journal of Disability Studies*, Vol. 9, No. 1-2, Jan-Dec 2015.

CONVENING, PANELS & CHAIRS

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1. Moderator, **World Health Innovation Forum**, AMTZ Vishakapatnam, 12 Dec 2024.
2. Jury member, **Assistive Technology Hackathon**, KIHT × AMTZ, 7-9 Apr 2025.
3. Panel member, '**Disability Justice: Looking Beyond Ableist Frames**', IDSK Kolkata, 12-13 Nov 2024.
4. Panellist, **University of Chicago Delhi Centre Round Table - 'Disentangling Disability and Human Rights'**.
5. Session Chair, '**Attitudinal and Communication Barriers**', JNU Natl. Conf. on Access to Higher Education, Mar 2015.
6. Co-Chair, '**Disability and Barrier-free Toileting in Indian Railways**', Indian Spinal Injuries Centre, Feb 2016.
7. Discussant, '**Disability and Social Inclusion**', JNU Natl. Conf. on Disability Studies in India.

FELLOWSHIPS, AWARDS & TRAINING

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1. **NIEPID** - ex-General Council member, National Institute for the Empowerment of Persons with Intellectual Disabilities, nominated by the Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment, Govt. of India.
2. **Distinguished Fellow**, Kalam Institute of Health Technology, WHO Collaborating Centre at AMTZ (2023-2025).
3. **SYLFF Fellowship** - Ryoichi Sasakawa Young Leaders Fund (Nippon & Tokyo Foundation), via JNU, 2010-2013.
4. **Sarai-CSDS Student Stipend Award**, 2005-06 - 'Invisible in New Delhi: Spatial Narrative of Disabled in City Public Spaces'.
5. **IHEID full scholarship**, Graduate Institute Geneva, 2019-2021.
6. **CPACC**, IAAP - Certified Professional in Accessibility Core Competencies.
7. **Built-Environment Accessibility**, NITS / BIS Capsule, May 2025.
8. **FICCI DEI Virtual Programme**, Feb-Apr 2025.
9. **CH-IBDN** Creating Disability-Inclusive Leaders @ Workplace, Jul-Aug 2024.
10. **Assistive Technology Solutions**, 6-mo. cert., NISH Trivandrum, 2023.
11. WHO Quality Rights Training - Mental Health, Recovery and Community Inclusion.
12. Action Aid Intl. Training Course in Disability & Development, Bangalore, 2011.